

Ensemble

The ensemble consists entirely of eighth grade students; the band program at our middle school is large enough where each grade has its own band, size ranging between 40-60 students. The current ensemble has about 50 students, with a strong saxophone and clarinet section, and weak trombone section.

Expression Lab Chart

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3
Creative Activity: At a random time of day, take a photo of the sky using your phone in landscape mode. Try to keep obstacles such as light poles or houses out of the way. Submit it online with a timestamp.	Creative Activity: At a random time of day, take a photo of the sky using your phone in landscape mode. Try to keep obstacles such as light poles or houses out of the way. Submit it online with a timestamp.	Creative Activity: At a random time of day, take a photo of the sky using your phone in landscape mode. Try to keep obstacles such as light poles or houses out of the way. Submit it online with a timestamp.
Chorale: 1. Tutti m. 30 - m. 38 2. Flutes, clarinets, trumpets: melody 3. Oboe, cl. 3, A. sax 1, Horn 1: countermelody 4. Bsn, B. Cl, T/B sax, all low brass: harmony 5. Ask students what differences do they hear about the movement of each section that just played Discuss the different dynamic level that everyone should play at based on what part they are playing	Sight reading: Give everyone a leadsheet for m. 30 - m. 34 for trumpet I. Everyone should look at it, consider key signature and tempo, and then play 1. Ensure students follow dynamic 2. Exaggerate dynamic Discuss why did the composer choose this specific set of dynamics Discuss patterns: melodic pattern in the four bars, ascending two-eighths and one quarter. Where does the music go or lead towards, and how do dynamics contribute towards it? Rehearse the segment one more time, emphasize the above	Sight reading: Discuss important steps to sightreading: - Key signature - Time signature - Tempo - Anything that looks hard - Everyone play through the trumpet solo from m. 12 - m. 16 using leadsheets Discuss the shape of the melody. Where does the melody want to go to, to which note? How about dynamics, phrasing and style? - Tutti band on the solo, bring out the dynamic contrast
Listening: Listen to one of the recordings, have students take notes on which sections they can hear the most in each (or any they can't) 1. Start at m. 24, play through m. 41. Play again 2. Ask students what they think 3. Play from beginning to m. 50	Technical Studies - The rhythm at m. 65 and m. 66 on a c minor scale - Repeat the scale with accents, emphasizing breath support and control - Play the scale at various dynamics	Listening Listen to another recording at the particular excerpt, to how the trumpet plays it or how the flutes play it. - Have students take notes about m. 12 - m. 20, be very particular about the phrase and dynamics - Discuss these artistic choices Tutti band m. 12 onwards towards m. 43

Day 4	Day 5
Creative Activity: At a random time of day, take a photo of the sky using your phone in landscape mode. Try to keep obstacles such as light poles or houses out of the way. Submit it online with a timestamp.	Creative Activity: At a random time of day, take a photo of the sky using your phone in landscape mode. Try to keep obstacles such as light poles or houses out of the way. Submit it online with a timestamp. Over the weekend and for next class: prepare a slideshow consisting of all the different photos taken at different times of the sky, show how it changes all the time - Discuss how this must be reflected through the music
Technical Studies Dotted eighth + 2 32nd note pattern, eg. at m. 22 - Draw this out on the whiteboard, then subdivide it into 32nds - Discuss with the class the importance of keeping tempo and sloppy subdivision - Add ties, slurs, and other forms of rhythm scaffolding so that the class can internalize it, through clapping or verbally - Play the pattern once, then play it on a scale with a metronome backing - In practice: leadsheet, flute m. 20 - m. 23, everyone reads and plays the rhythm	Sight reading: Flute I. m. 59 - m. 68 - Go over the steps of sightreading - Time changes! Students should look for those when sightreading - Accidentals - After 1 or 2 playthroughs, discuss the melodic movement, how the composer builds the intensity through the ascension of the melody - Accents, articulations
Chorale: m. 41 - m. 50 - Discuss the “buildup” to the climax at m. 50, how this is achieved through the melodic movement and dynamic choices - Dynamic contrast and context. Even though the parts are written forte, in context they should be quiet and lead to a forte - Show which instruments in the band play the moving lines in m. 48 and m. 49	Listening Listen to the last recording of m. 50 - m. 84 Ask students to listen to the articulation, dynamic contrast, and the balance of the band during this dogfight section - Which section is the most audible? Which do you think is playing a forte? - Are there any sections that are rushing or dragging? How can we put this into practice? - Consider your part, within the bigger picture. Do you have the melody or harmony, and what dynamic should you play? - Listen to your neighbors

Justifications

Chorales

Chorale excerpts will be carefully chosen from the music, with certain tutti measures being used as educational examples of expression, phrasing, and part balance. Since this piece is both slow, lyrical and fast and intense, there are tons of excerpts to choose and use as teaching examples. In this section of the learning lab, students learn how to listen to others outside of their section, how dynamic contrast is used to build style, and what melodic movement can mean.

On paper, the excerpts I chose for the chorales section seem very short, and may not have “enough” material for students to find them interesting. However I know that for each measure there can be tons of nuance, and therefore everything should be worked on from dynamics, phrasing, to melodic contrast, to breathing, and tempo.

“The director can ask students to memorize a phrase quickly and then focus on conducting cues for tempo, dynamics, intonation, balance, and blend; the director should then shape that phrase in a variety of musical ways.”²

Technical Studies

This piece isn’t on the technical side, compared to some other pieces in the grade level, so most of the studies I picked were on articulation and rhythmic precision. It’s easy for intermediate bands (or any level of band) to rush or drag in important spots, so learning tempo tendencies and how to address them is important.

Sight Reading

Again this piece isn’t too difficult, so the excerpts I picked should be fairly sightreadable to the typical middle/early high schooler. One important thing to note are the time changes, this piece is full of them and can catch students off guard.

Telling students what to look for, before they sight read, seems like an obvious choice to make but at a middle school/early high school level, many students may not know where to begin.

“When the sight-reading portion of the music learning lab begins, students should be coached on what to seek out before the playing begins.”¹

Creative Activity

I especially enjoyed planning this aspect because I’ve recently gotten to appreciate how beautiful the sky can be, and I’d like to share that with my class if I were to teach this piece. Since everyone has phones, students should take pictures of the sky regularly throughout the week, and everyone should submit them to me, where I’ll compile a slideshow of each day and how the sky changes- the clouds, shapes, colors, atmospheres, moods and intensities. This would be a great teaching example of contrast and expression.

Listening

From an educational standpoint I especially agree with listening to other recordings. I’d make my class listen to tons of interpretations and performances, have them take notes on what they like or what they disagree with. There will be discussions on what the band wants the piece to sound like and what interpretations are more or less agreeable.

It is also helpful that they get to know what an excellent high school ensemble sounds like playing a piece currently in their folders, and perhaps a mediocre ensemble as well.¹

1: Colwell, Richard J.; Hewitt, Michael P.. The Teaching of Instrumental Music (p. 98).

2: Colwell, Richard J.; Hewitt, Michael P.. The Teaching of Instrumental Music (p. 97).



BAND

Assessment Form

Updated 2026

Performance #: _____ MPA Date: _____ MPA Site: _____
 School: Henderson High School Ensemble Name: Wind Ensemble Declared Grade Level: _____

SCORE	EVALUATION AREA	COMMENTS
SCORE = RATING with DESCRIPTORS 13-15 I Superior A+ Outstanding 10-12 II Excellent A Advanced 7-9 III Good B Proficient 4-6 IV Fair C Basic 1-3 V Unprepared U Below Basic	SPECIFIC ASPECTS + Area of strength; Noticeably strong within rating Blank Commensurate to rating - Area of concern; Noticeably needing attention within rating	Use the space below and on the back for specific written input focusing on identifying and enhancing areas of strength as well as identifying and addressing areas of concern.

SCORE	EVALUATION AREA	COMMENTS
54	TONE 13 Quality/Clarity/Characteristic Sound 14 Consistency (throughout range of pitch & dynamics) 13 Blend (within parts/sections/family/ensemble) 14 Balance (between sections; within the harmony & texture)	Excellent trumpet solo, but when the flutes picked up the melody it fell short; the energy wasn't there Tutti band entrances following solo sections are abrupt and aren't in context Tuning is great. Excellent intonation across all sections Plenty of layering and great balance Piano dynamics aren't very quiet, not very much contrast
56	INTONATION 15 Consistency (throughout range of pitch & dynamics) 14 Within & between sections 14 Within the musical line (horizontal) 12 Within the harmony & texture (vertical)	
44	ACCURACY 15 Time & Meter 15 Notes & Rhythms 14 Articulation (beginnings/slurs/releases)	
30	TECHNIQUE 15 Consistency/Facility/Dexterity 15 Unity (vertical alignment)	
75	EXPRESSION 14 Through Articulation 14 Through Tempo 10 Through Dynamics 12 Through Phrasing (shaping of notes & lines) 12 Through Texture (reflecting the changing roles of parts throughout) 12 Unity of Idiomatic Style/Interpretation	
TOTAL Add the five scores above	FINAL RATING Convert the Total Score to the Final Rating according to the table on the right using the Roman numeral only. Do not include a '-' or a '+'	TOTAL SCORE to FINAL RATING with DESCRIPTORS 63-75 I A+ (63-68 low I) (67-71 I) (72-75 high I) Superior/Outstanding 48-62 II A (48-52 low II) (53-57 II) (58-62 high II) Excellent/Advanced 33-47 III B (33-37 low III) (38-42 III) (43-47 high III) Good/Proficient 18-32 IV C (18-22 low IV) (23-27 IV) (28-32 high IV) Fair/Basic 5-17 V U Unprepared/Below Basic

OTHER FACTORS (+, Blank or -) (Not scored; does not affect Final Rating) ☐ Conduct, Appearance & Posture ☐ Choice of Repertoire ☐ Conducting & Response to Conducting	Adjudicator Signature _____
--	-----------------------------